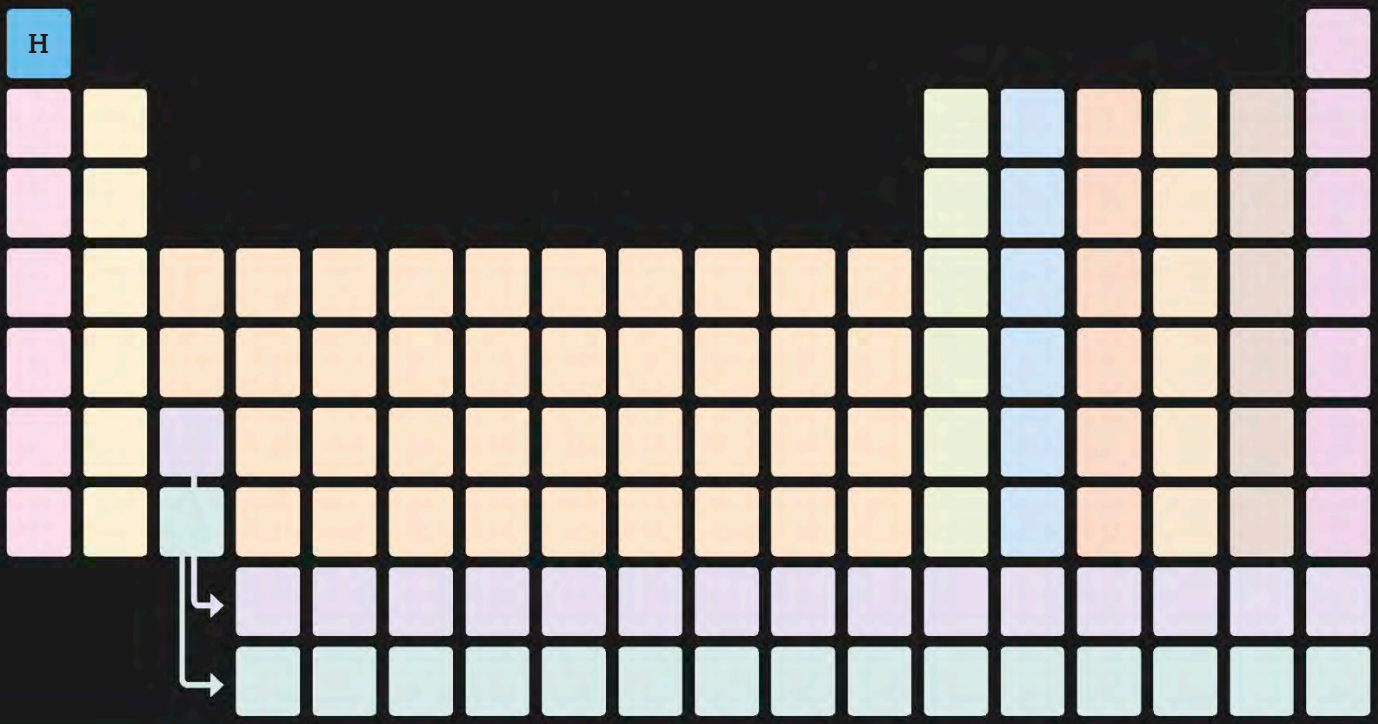

Hydrogen

The first element, hydrogen (H), is located above the alkali metals in the first column of the periodic table. However, because it is so different to the elements below it, hydrogen is not included in their group. This gas has the simplest atoms of any element with one electron and one proton. It is highly reactive and forms compounds with all kinds of other elements.

Atomic structure
A hydrogen (H) atom has one electron moving around a nucleus consisting of a single proton.

Physical properties
Hydrogen gas is the lightest material in the Universe. Pure hydrogen is rare on Earth, as it escapes quickly from the atmosphere into space.

Chemical properties
Hydrogen is highly flammable. It forms compounds with both metals and non-metals.

Compounds
The most common hydrogen compound is water. Acids are compounds that contain hydrogen.